

USDA Comparative Evaluation

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Harvesting Insights: Usability Study of the ACIR Database

SI 622

THE TEAM



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Introduction:

Purpose:

Evaluate how effectively users navigate, interpret, and apply regulatory information in the Agricultural Commodity Import Requirements (ACIR) portal.

Project Focus:

- Assess navigation, search, and filter usability
- Evaluate clarity and organization of help resources
- Examine mobile experience and small-form-factor use cases

Key Research Areas:

- Efficiency of upfront vs. post-search filtering
- User ability to locate commodity-specific requirements
- Effectiveness of current help pathways (labels, videos, guides)
- Opportunities for a centralized “single help hub”



ACIR Search Tools - Locator Table and Frequently Searched

Are you looking for a way to browse topics in ACIR? Would you like a prebuilt search list of Commodity Import Requirements (CIRs) on a specific topic?

There are two Search Tools available in ACIR:

- **Locator Table** - Found on the [ACIR Help Page](#)
 - Allows users to browse various commodities and locate specialty items in ACIR.
 - Topics are listed alphabetically and include Bags/Bagging, Bee Products, Corn, Fresh Fruits and Vegetables, Herbarium Specimens, Lichen, Live Plants, Plant Oils, Seed Kits, Wooden Handicrafts and much more.
- **Frequently Searched** - Found on all search tile pages, above the Search button
 - Allows users to choose prebuilt searches for quick and easy results based on the tile content.
 - [Plants and Plant Products Not for Propagation](#) has the most topics available (e.g., Seeds, Nuts, and Grains - Fresh Fruit and Vegetables from a certain country - Handicrafts - Mushrooms - Tea Products, etc.)
 - Click on the Select button to the right of the topic to view the search results with commodity import requirements related to the topic.

Methods

01

Selection Process

Comparators were selected based on data density, shared user goals, and the need to navigate high-stakes information accurately.

02

Comparison Products

We compared the ACIR Portal with eCFR, APHIS Manuals, Microsoft Learn, and GOV.UK across multiple comparator types.

03

Evaluation Criteria

Each product was assessed for navigation, search functionality, information hierarchy, scannability, terminology clarity, and accessibility.

04

Analysis Process

Findings were synthesized in a comparative matrix to identify patterns, friction points, and opportunities for improvement.

Key Findings/Recommendations

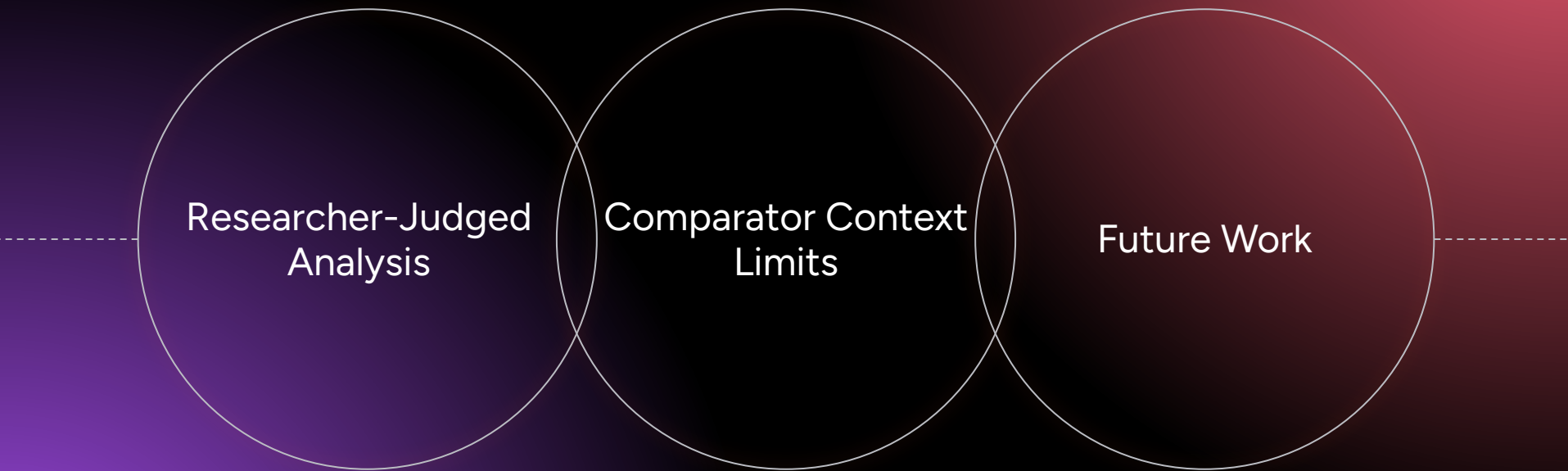
- **Search Rigidity:** Users cannot search flexibly by country, commodity, or free text, which makes early information retrieval harder.
- **Weak Information Hierarchy:** Dense, hyperlink-heavy content makes guidance difficult to scan, interpret, and navigate efficiently.

- **Limited Cross-Linking:** Related content like treatments, taxonomy, and regulatory references is not well connected across the portal.
- **Expert-Heavy Terminology:** Regulatory labels assume prior knowledge and can be difficult for less experienced users to understand.
- **Poor Result Preview:** Users often have to click into content before they can judge whether it is relevant, slowing down review and increasing effort.

Recommendations

- **Improve Search Flexibility:** Support country-only, commodity-only, and free-text queries, with spelling correction and preview text.
- **Strengthen Scannability:** Add tables of contents, in-page anchors, and stronger visual cues to support faster review of dense guidance.
- **Expand Contextual Linking:** Make referenced treatments, facilities, and taxonomy terms clickable, with related-content pathways.
- **Clarify Terminology:** Add plain-language descriptions, tooltips, and guided entry points for first-time or less experienced users.

Discussions/Future Work



THANK YOU

Any questions?